

Young adults

By around the age of 20, the body is fully developed. Young people live independently and may form close sexual relationships. They may try to have children.

Middle age

Between the ages of 40 and 60, thinking and reasoning reaches a peak, although signs of ageing begin to appear. Some adults are still having children and caring for them. By later middle age, women can no longer have babies.

Old age

In this final phase of the human life cycle, clear signs of ageing appear. These can include gray hair, wrinkled skin, poorer vision and hearing, and stiffer joints. This “slowing down” can be lessened by regular exercise and a healthy diet.

Humans

We are *Homo sapiens*—an intelligent species of mammal that can live for more than 100 years. Parents care for their young for many years, longer than most other mammals. Around the world, humans vary greatly—in terms of height, weight, appearance, and more.

See also

Read about orangutans (130–131)—a close relative of humans—who also look after their young for a long period of time.

Pregnancy The baby develops inside the mother for nine months until birth. At 12 weeks, it begins to grow nails. The baby can recognize its mother's voice at 24 weeks. A month later, the baby's hair starts to grow and the eyelids open.

